

## Olympus C350

Low on price, high on features

The C350 belongs to the Camedia series of digital cameras from Olympus. Similar in size and shape to its younger sibling, the C150, this camera packs in quite a number of features at a very attractive price. It runs on two normal AA alkaline batteries, and features a nice LCD display to preview your subject before you actually shoot it. The menu navigation is not as intuitive as the others in this category, such as the ones from Canon and Fuji.

As far as physical features and ergonomics are concerned, the C350 was the best in this segment. It fits perfectly in your palm, with the contoured front lens cover providing a good grip. Its design is pretty plane devoid of unnecessary lines jarring its usability.

On the features front, the C350 does not disappoint either; it has a 2 megapixel CCD sensor, with a 3X optical zoom and 3.3X of digital zoom, giving it a 9X zooming capability. The C-350 also comes with four preset white balance modes along with the default Auto mode. Shutter speeds vary from 2 seconds



to 1/1000th of a second, allowing photographs to be taken in all sorts of lighting conditions. A choice of seven different flash modes

lets you click away in any sort of lighting. The C350 comes with a huge 32 MB xD memory card.

Coming to performance, the C-350 is on par with the Kodak DX6340. In the Image test, it produced images with good tonal balance across the entire frame. The deviation of all the colours from the reference points was not more than 10 per cent. The photograph was sufficiently bright, with no dark spots at the corner of the frame. In the specular test, the C350 produced mild effects, thus losing some points. However, the gradation in shading test saw the C350 performing much better, picking up all the shading effects properly.

The C350 put up a mediocre performance in the details test, and wasn't able to reproduce all the required details very well. In the RGB target test, the camera showed good response to red and blue. However, the same wasn't true in the case of green. In the zoom and actual person test, the C350 yielded more than decent photographs—it actually did better in this test than our eventual winner—the Kodak DX6340.

Priced at Rs 19,995, the C-350 offers good value for money, with a decent enough performance and good features. An added benefit is the JPEG Exif version 2.2 image compression format that allows you to add data to the picture that can be used by a printer to accurately perform image adjustment before printing.

+ Great features at attractive price  
– Average performance  
Price: Rs 19,995

| Olympus C350    | B     |
|-----------------|-------|
| Performance     | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Features        | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Ergonomics      | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Value for money | ▶▶▶▶▶ |

## Casio QV-R3

Rugged digicam seeks memory

The Casio QV-R3 is a 3.2-megapixel digital camera that can capture stills, as well as video. It supports a resolution of 2048 x 1536, and features a 3X optical and a 3.2X digital zoom. It is small and compact owing to Casio's Multi-Chip Module (MCM) technology that integrates the CPU, ASIC and the memory chip into a single unit.

ISO selection is set to auto by default, but users can select ISO 125 or 250, manually. The metering can be configured to multi, centre-weighted, or spot. It also has filters with such tones as black and white, sepia, red, green, blue, yellow, pink and purple. The camera comes with a Li-ion battery and a charger, both of which add to its convenience and portability. You save substantially on the running cost of the camera, which is a cause for concern for most, and the Li-ion battery ensures long battery-life. The 11 MB internal memory, and the SD/MMC card support provides for additional memory expansions. The QV-R3 has very rugged looks, owing to the steel body and is really light. The menu navigation is also easy and icon-based, so that even a novice can understand the different settings without much head-scratching.

The specular effect was high, causing images to be too bright—the excessive light caused the numerals on the clock to disappear. However, it didn't disappoint in the actual person test, where it delivered a proper contrast, and set the white balance to provide near-real environment images. It also picked up colours without any loss under natural lighting conditions. Hence, the camera can provide good indoor shoots.

The zoom test returned acceptable results with the object being very clear. This camera failed to pick up green, and scored as low as 55.51 out of 255, which is worrying. It needs a bit of tweaking that involves selecting a lower shutter speeds to let maximum light enter the camera, for better colour reproduction.

Priced at Rs 29,995, it is a bit expensive, considering that the built-in memory is just 11 MB. It has no additional memory card either. However, if you are looking for a rugged camera that has re-chargeable batteries and a charger, then look no further.



"Virtually similar to the IXUS4000 and easier on the pocket too. Isn't very fast between frames but is still faster than the standard aim-and-shoot conventional cameras. Worth the price, but nothing like a few thousand rupees less to attract the serious amateur."

—Sherwin Crasto

+ Rugged build-quality  
– Low internal memory  
Price: Rs 29,995

| Casio QV-R3     | C     |
|-----------------|-------|
| Performance     | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Features        | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Ergonomics      | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Value for money | ▶▶▶▶▶ |